JFVP
JUSTICE FOR FRAUD VICTIMS PROJECT

QUICK ANALYSIS GUIDE

Bank Statement Analyzer

A step-by-step method for analyzing bank statements in a fraud case, with a practice case and workpapers.

For accounting and fraud examination students

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1. The method at a glance

The analyzer does the reading, the arithmetic and the first pass for red flags. The judgment is yours: deciding what matters, following it up, and saying only what the records support.

Work through eight steps, in order. Each fills one or two sheets of the **workpaper template** (*Forensic_Workpaper_Template.xlsx*, linked in the app's sidebar under **Student materials**). The sheet references are in brackets.

1. Scope

Write down the questions you were asked, and the limits of the work. [A-1]

2. Organize and fingerprint

List every document, where it came from, and each statement's SHA-256. [A-2]

3. Prove every statement

Load the statements; confirm each one reconciles before you rely on it. [B-1]

4. Check authenticity

Read the Document Check for each file: edited? AI-generated? [D-2]

5. Sources and uses

Summarize money in and out by month, so the unusual stands out. [B-2]

6. Red flags

Log every flag and follow each one up until it is explained or isn't. [D-1]

7. Trace the money

Follow each significant payment, and the cash, to where it arrived. [C-1, C-2, C-3]

8. Quantify and report

Build the amount from the workpapers; write findings the records support. [E-1, F-1, R-1]

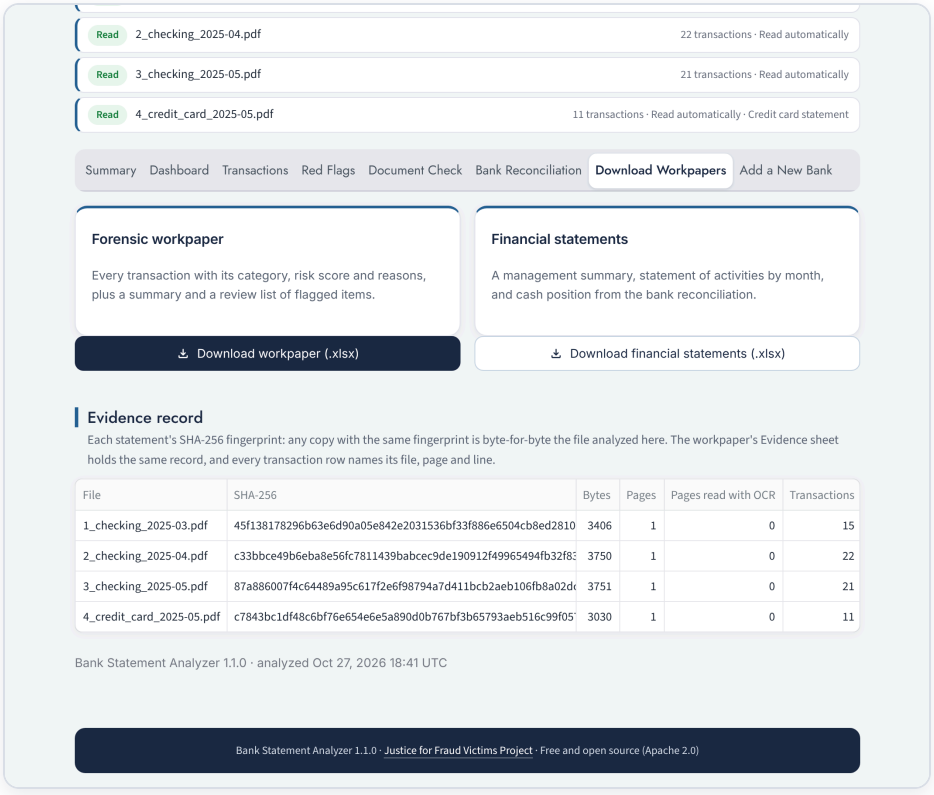
THREE RULES FOR THE WHOLE ANALYSIS

- **Prove before you rely.** A number from a statement that doesn't reconcile, or a statement that may not be genuine, isn't evidence yet.
- **Flags are leads, not conclusions.** A payment to a caregiver can be wages. Find out.
- **Every number has a source.** Each figure in your findings points to a workpaper, and each workpaper to a document, page and line.

2. Organize and fingerprint the documents

Before any analysis, know exactly what you have, where it came from, and what you were asked. [A-1, A-2]

1. **Write down the questions.** Copy each question from the engagement letter into A-1, in the client's words. Your findings will answer them one by one.
2. **Index every document.** On A-2, give each a number and record what it is, who produced it, how you got it (from the bank, by subpoena, from the client, from the other side) and when.
3. **Separate bank-produced records from copies.** A statement downloaded by the bank or produced under subpoena is stronger evidence than a copy someone handed over. Note which is which.
4. **Fingerprint each statement.** Load the statements in the app, open `Download Workpapers`, and copy each file's **SHA-256** from the Evidence record into A-2. If anyone later questions which file you analyzed, the same file gives the same fingerprint.
5. **Use a project for real cases.** In the sidebar, `New project` keeps the statements, your notes and a log of what was done together, encrypted with your password.



The Evidence record: each file's SHA-256 fingerprint, size, pages and transaction count.

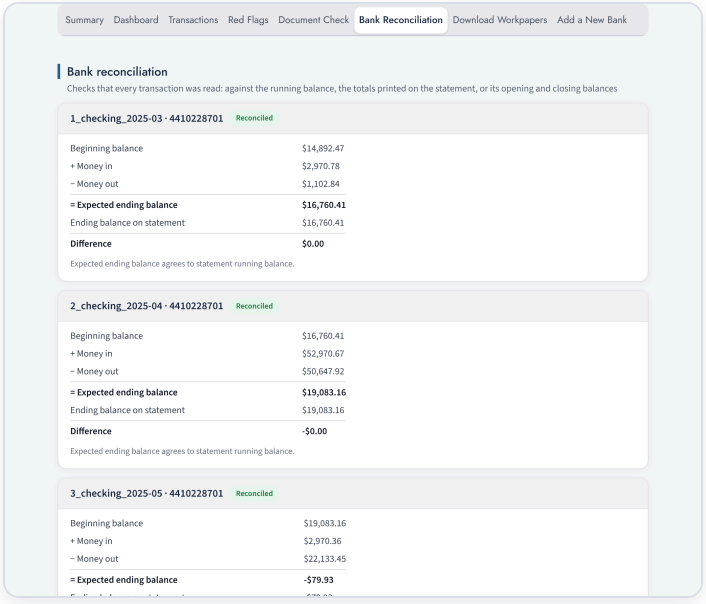
3. Prove every statement

Before you use a single number, show that the analyzer read each statement completely. [B-1]

1. Drag the statements onto **Upload statements**. Check the file list: every file should say **Read** with a transaction count.
2. Open **Bank Reconciliation**. Each account shows one of three results:

Result	What it means	What you do
Reconciled	The transactions read agree with the balances or totals the bank printed	Rely on the figures; record it on B-1
Variance	They don't: a line was missed or misread, or the statement was altered	Compare the Transactions tab with the PDF line by line before going further
Needs Review	The statement doesn't print enough to check against	Prove it by hand on B-1

3. Record each statement on B-1: beginning balance, deposits and withdrawals from the detail, and the ending balance the bank printed. The sheet computes the difference.
4. Look for **gaps in the months**. A missing statement is a missing month of activity: request it.



Each statement's beginning balance, money in and out, and the ending balance the bank printed.

4. Check that each document is genuine

Fraud cases attract fake documents. Statements are edited to hide transactions, and now they are also written from scratch by AI tools. The **Document Check** tab looks for the traces of both. [D-2]

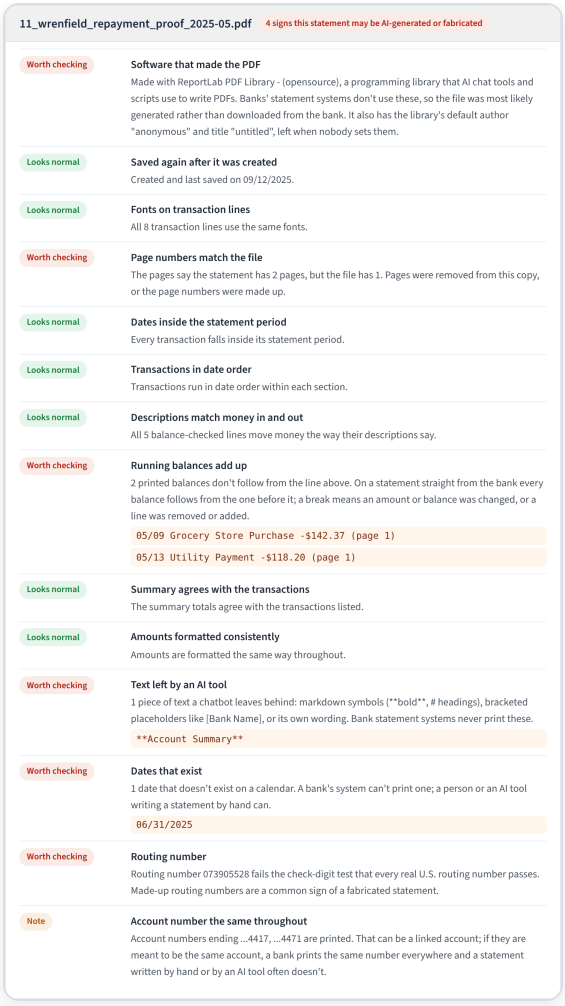
Signs a statement was edited

Check	What a warning means
Software that made the PDF	Saved by a PDF editor or office program. Banks don't produce statements with these.
Saved again after it was created	The file was changed days or weeks after the bank issued it.
Fonts on transaction lines	A few lines are in a different font: typed over the original.
Dates inside the period / in date order	A line pasted in from another month, or moved.
Descriptions match money in and out	"Payment *from*" on money that went out: a relabelled payment.
Running balances / summary agree	An amount, balance or total was changed without the others.
Amounts formatted consistently	A figure typed by hand ($13763.86 among $1,234.56s).

Signs a statement was written by an AI tool

Ask an AI chat tool for "a bank statement showing these payments" and it will write one. Such files leave different traces, and two or more make the app report **"may be AI-generated or fabricated"**.

Check	What a warning means
Software that made the PDF	A programming library (ReportLab, FPDF, wkhtmltopdf and others): what AI tools and scripts use to write PDFs.
Text left by an AI tool	Markdown symbols like `**Account Summary**`, placeholders like `[Bank Name]`, or chatbot wording.
Dates that exist	A date like 06/31 or February 30: a bank's system can't print one.
Routing number	The number fails the check digit that every real U.S. routing number passes.
Page numbers match the file	"Page 1 of 2" on a one-page file: pages missing, or made up.
Account number the same throughout	Different numbers in different places (a note: it can also be a linked account).



The practice case's "proof of repayment": four signs of an AI-generated statement, plus a page count and running balances that don't add up.

THEN CHECK THE CONTENT

The strongest test isn't in the file at all. Do the transactions appear on the other side? A claimed transfer to the victim should appear as a deposit on the victim's own statement. A payroll deposit should appear on the employer's statement. Record these on D-2 under "By hand".

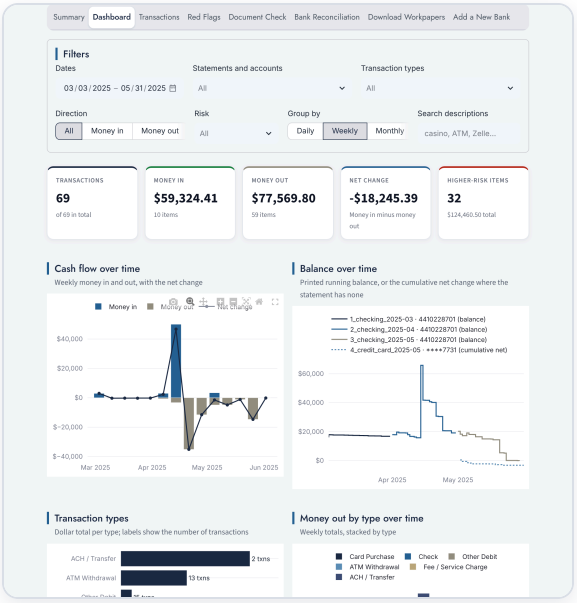
WHAT A RESULT MEANS

A warning is a reason to get the statement **directly from the bank**, or by subpoena. A clean result does not prove a statement is genuine.

5. See where the money went

A sources and uses summary turns hundreds of transactions into one page a reader can follow. [B-2]

1. Open the **Dashboard**. Read the balance-over-time chart first: a steady account, then a spike and a slide, is the shape of many exploitation cases.
2. Use the filters: Direction **Money out**, Group by **Monthly**, and the search box to isolate a payee or a merchant.
3. On B-2, total each month's money in by source and money out by use. Make the uses tell the story: ordinary living expenses, payments to the subject or related parties, cash, gambling, gift cards, fees.
4. Compare the months. What changed, when, and what happened just before it (a new caregiver, a CD maturing, a change of phone number)?
5. The check row on B-2 must be zero. If it isn't, a transaction is missing or counted twice.

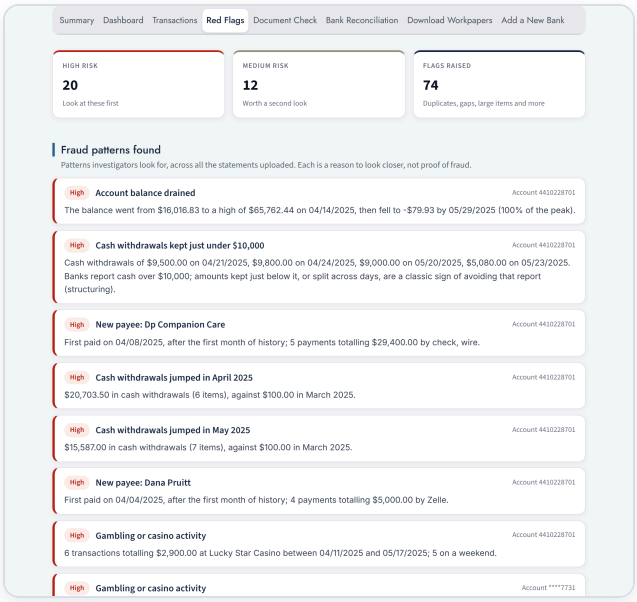


The Dashboard: filters, totals, weekly cash flow and the balance over time.

6. Follow up the red flags

The **Red Flags** tab lists patterns investigators look for, most serious first. Each is a question to answer, not an answer. [D-1]

Pattern	Questions to ask
New payee taking large sums	Who is it? Is there an agreement, invoices, a reason the payments started when they did?
Cash kept just under $10,000	Who made the withdrawals? Where did the cash go? (Banks report cash over $10,000; staying under on purpose is called structuring.)
Money in and straight back out	Is the account a pass-through? Where did the money go next?
Balance drained; cash jumped	What changed at the start? Who had access?
Gambling, gift cards, cash advances	Does this match the account holder's habits and abilities (can they drive to the casino)?
Duplicate payments, check gaps, overdrafts	Were both payments authorized? Where are the missing checks?



Fraud patterns found, each with what was found and on which account.

1. Copy each flag into D-1 with its account, dates and amount.
2. Write what you did to follow each one up and the result, then close it as **explained** (with the support), **unexplained** or **referred**. Add the flags you find yourself.

7. Trace the money across banks

Tracing answers the question every client asks: where did the money go? It needs the receiving side's records, usually by subpoena. [C-1, C-2, C-3]

Load both sides together

Upload the victim's statements and the recipient's statements together. The analyzer reads each bank's layout, reconciles each account, and looks for patterns across all of them: the same cash showing up as deposits, money arriving and leaving within days.

Match each payment [C-1]

Method	How to match it
Check	The check image: payee, endorsement on the back (which account it was deposited to), and the deposit on the recipient's statement one to three days earlier
Wire	The wire record: beneficiary, bank and account number, and the same amount arriving the same day
Zelle / transfers	The confirmation number or the sender's name, same day
Cash	Cash deposits in the subject's accounts a few days later, often a little less than withdrawn [C-3]

Paid versus supported [C-2]

For each payee, compare what was paid with what a document supports: an agreement's rate, invoices, receipts. The calculator on C-2 works out the most a caregiver could have earned under an hourly agreement.

Follow it one more step

Money that arrives in a business account and leaves within days for a personal account, a car dealer or a casino tells you what the business is for. Keep tracing until the money is spent or the records run out, and say where they ran out.

SEARCH ACROSS STATEMENTS

The **Transactions** tab's search box covers every statement loaded. Search a name ("Pruitt"), a reference number, or an amount.

8. Quantify and report

Build the amount from the workpapers, one component at a time, and say what each rests on. [E-1, F-1, R-1]

1. **List the components on E-1:** unsupported payments to the subject, cash traced to the subject's deposits, unexplained items. Mark each with its basis and whether it is included.
2. **Keep the bases separate.** "Traced to the subject" is stronger than "unexplained". The summary on E-1 shows the total both ways.
3. **Answer each question on F-1**, with the amount and the workpapers behind it.
4. **Write what the records show, not what you believe.** See the table below.
5. **Clear the review notes** on R-1 before the file is final.

Write	Not
"The $24,000 wire was deposited to the LLC's account and $18,750 left the next day by check to a car dealer."	"Dana stole the money to buy a car."
"The statement is not consistent with the account holder's bank records, which show no such deposits."	"The statement is a forgery."
"The signatures on checks 2047 and 2048 differ from those on 2043 and 2044; a document examiner should compare them."	"The checks were forged."
"We could not trace $6,600 of ATM cash, cash advances and gift cards."	(Leaving it out)

LEAVE INTENT TO THE COURT

Findings say whether the records are **consistent** or **not consistent** with the explanations offered. Whether anyone intended fraud is for the trier of fact.

9. Practice: the Hartwell case

A complete fictional case: four banks, eleven statements and nine case documents, every page marked as a sample.

The story: Evelyn Hartwell, 81, hires a caregiver, Dana Pruitt, who bills through DP Companion Care LLC. In two months her account goes from about $16,000, plus a $50,000 CD, to overdrawn. Her daughter's lawyer engages you.

Files	What they are
1 to 4	Evelyn's checking (March to May) and credit card (May), Larkspur Valley Bank
5, 6	The "family copy" of April that Dana gave the family; a scanned, redacted May (for OCR)
7, 8	DP Companion Care LLC's business checking, Quillbrook Credit Union (subpoenaed)
9, 10	Dana Pruitt's personal checking, Oxbow Prairie National Bank (subpoenaed)
11	The Wrenfield Trust Bank statement Dana's attorney sent as proof of repayment
Exhibits A-I	Engagement letter, interview notes, caregiver agreement, invoice, CD notice, account change letter, wire confirmation, check images, opposing counsel's letter

In the app, **Try the full case** loads files 1 to 4 and 7 to 10; **Try a doctored statement** and **Try an AI-generated statement** load files 5 and 11 next to the real ones. Download everything with **Hartwell case pack (.zip)** under **Student materials**.

Exercises

1. Read Exhibit A. Put its five questions on A-1.
2. Index all twenty documents on A-2 with the statements' fingerprints. Which came from a bank, and which from someone with an interest in the outcome?
3. Prove every statement on B-1. Which one doesn't reconcile, and why?
4. Complete D-2 for files 5 and 11. Then test file 11's content: do its two "loan repayments" appear anywhere in Evelyn's records?
5. Build B-2 for Evelyn's checking. What happened on April 3, April 14 and April 15? (Exhibits E, F and G help.)
6. Trace the checks, the wire and the Zelle payments on C-1, and the cash on C-3. How much of the cash reappears, and where?
7. Compare the payments with Exhibits C and D [C-2]; answer the five questions [E-1, F-1].

10. One-page checklist

- [ ] The client's questions are on A-1, in their words, with the limits of the work.
- [ ] Every document is on A-2: source, how obtained, date, and each statement's SHA-256.
- [ ] Every statement reconciles on B-1, or the variance is explained. No months are missing.
- [ ] Every statement has a Document Check result on A-2 and D-2. Questioned documents were tested against the other side's records.
- [ ] Any warning led to a request for the statement directly from the bank.
- [ ] B-2 shows sources and uses by month, and its check row is zero.
- [ ] Every red flag is on D-1 with its follow-up, and is explained, unexplained or referred.
- [ ] Every significant payment is on C-1, traced or with the reason it couldn't be.
- [ ] Cash withdrawals are on C-3, with any matching deposits.
- [ ] Payments to each key payee are compared with what is supported on C-2.
- [ ] The amount on E-1 is built from components, each with its basis and workpaper.
- [ ] Each question has an answer on F-1 that the records support, written as consistent or not consistent.
- [ ] What could not be determined, and the record that would settle it, is stated.
- [ ] Review notes on R-1 are cleared; the Index is signed off.

KEEP THE FILE TOGETHER

Save the app's workpaper (it carries the Evidence record and every transaction's source page and line) with your template workbook. For a real case, keep everything in an encrypted project and never upload real statements to a public demo.

Instructors: the answer key for the Hartwell case is demo/ANSWER_KEY.md in the app's download (it is not in the case pack).